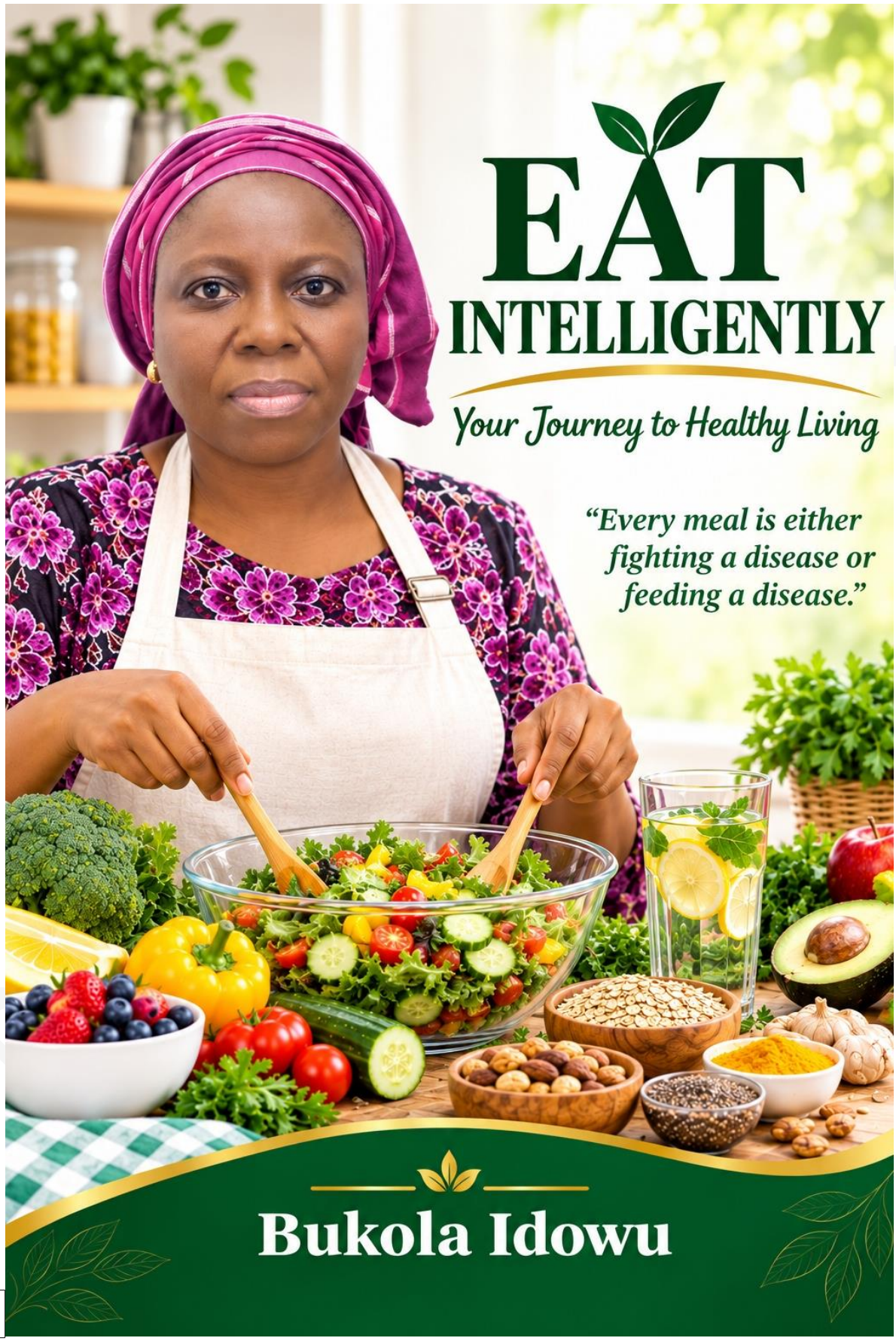


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EAT INTELLIGENTLY

Your Journey To Healthy Living

BUKOLA IDOWU

Acknowledgements

First and foremost, I give all glory and gratitude to God Almighty for the grace, wisdom and strength to birth this vision and see this dream come true. Without His grace, this journey would not have been possible.

To my immediate nuclear family, thank you for being a strong pillar of support throughout this journey. Your encouragement, patience and unwavering support have meant more to me than words can express.

My heartfelt appreciation goes to my mentors and teachers, particularly Rev. Tony Akinyemi, whose teachings and passion for healthy living have greatly influenced my journey.

I am equally grateful to Mummy Dammylove, whose teachings and practical knowledge in naturopathy and the therapeutic uses of natural substances; particularly herbs, spices and natural oils have enriched my understanding of natural approaches to health and wellbeing. Her guidance has been an important part of my learning journey.

I also deeply appreciate everyone who has given me a platform to share the knowledge I have gained through workshops, trainings, consultations, seminars and other opportunities. Thank you for trusting me, listening to me and allowing me to share this message of healthy living.

To everyone who has contributed, directly or indirectly, to this journey, I am sincerely grateful.

May the knowledge shared through these pages continue to inspire healthier choices and better lives.

BLOOMDOM

Foreword

In a world saturated with dietary advice, lifestyle-related diseases continue to escalate at an alarming rate. Many know *what* to eat, but remain uncertain about *how*, *when*, and *why* to eat to cultivate true, lasting health. In *Eat Intelligently*, Mrs. Bukola Grace Idowu delivers a practical, timely, and empowering response to this modern challenge.

This book elevates food beyond simple sustenance, reframing it as a divine gift designed to sustain life, protect health, and enhance overall well-being. Through clear, accessible writing, the author inspires readers to become intentional about their daily food choices, turning every meal into a conscious step towards wellness.

The true strength of this work lies in its balance. Rejecting short-term fad diets and extreme restrictions, it advocates for sustainable lifestyle habits grounded in solid nutritional science. Readers will find invaluable guidance on constructing balanced meals, utilizing seasonal whole foods, practicing portion control, retaining nutrient value in cooking, and leveraging food as a powerful tool for disease prevention, healing, and graceful ageing.

Crucially, the author emphasizes that health is achieved not by sporadic effort, but by informed, daily consistency. Her inclusion of practical action steps and reflective prompts converts knowledge into lasting behavioural change.

Equally inspiring is her seamless integration of Biblical principles, reminding us that honouring our physical health is a sacred act of responsibility and stewardship. This spiritual dimension lends the work profound depth, inspiring readers to pursue wellness not merely for longevity, but to honour the lives and bodies entrusted to us by God.

Whether you are taking your first steps towards better health, upgrading your family's nutrition, or working to prevent disease, *Eat Intelligently* offers clear, accessible, and inspiring direction. It calls us to move beyond routine habits and embrace eating with purpose, knowledge, understanding, and discipline.

I commend Mrs. Bukola Grace Idowu for her diligence, passion, and unwavering commitment to health education. Having been an ardent follower of my lectures and weekly broadcasts: '*EXPOSE WITH TONY AKINYEMI'* (Mondays at 8:00 PM WAT on YouTube and Facebook) and also a protege of Rapha Institute of Healthy Living (RIHL) she has demonstrated a thorough mastery of the principles of healthy living that I have been sharing for more than 25 years now. I am deeply gratified to watch dedicated advocates like her step forward to join this crusade and amplify the message of health restoration and disease prevention through intelligent eating and appropriate lifestyle.

May every reader be enriched by these pages, allowing its principles to transform their daily choices and inspire a lifetime of intelligent, purposeful eating.

'Tony Akinyemi
President, Rapha Institute of Healthy Living
Founding Pastor, The Shepherd's Flock International Church
September 9, 2026

BUKOLA IDOWU

Preface

This journal is the product of a journey. A journey that began with a desire to understand food beyond simply satisfying hunger.

For almost a decade, I have made conscious and intentional efforts to learn, practise and embrace the principles of intelligent eating and healthy living. Along the way, I have been privileged to learn from authorities and practitioners whose knowledge has challenged me to rethink what I eat, how I eat and the choices I make every day.

A major influence on this journey has been Rev. Tony Akinyemi, a foremost crusader of healthy living, whose teachings have profoundly shaped my understanding of nutrition and lifestyle. His enduring message, **"What we need is more education and not medication, because the best prescription is knowledge," has remained a guiding principle in my journey.**

His teachings form the bedrock of this journal.
Eat Intelligently was born from a desire to share the knowledge, lessons and insights gathered along this journey and to encourage others to become more intentional about their health. It is my hope that these pages will inspire you to look at food differently—not merely as something that satisfies hunger, but as something that can nourish, protect and support the body.

This is not a journey towards perfection. It is a journey towards knowledge, mindfulness and better choices. One meal, one habit and one day at a time.

As you turn these pages, my sincere hope is that you will not only learn to eat intelligently but also be inspired to live intelligently.

Welcome to your journey to healthy living.

With love for healthy living,
Mrs Idowu Bukola

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Introduction

Food is more than something we eat; it is one of the daily choices through which we care for our bodies. Yet, knowing what to eat, how much to eat and how to make better choices can sometimes feel confusing.

To eat intelligently is to approach food with knowledge and intention. It means paying attention to the quality, quantity and variety of what we consume, while understanding how our eating habits can influence our overall wellbeing.

Eat Intelligently is a practical guide to help you develop this awareness. It takes you through simple principles of healthy eating and living, encouraging you to examine your habits, make informed choices and embrace changes that can become part of your everyday life.

This is not about perfection, deprivation or following complicated rules. It is about learning to make better choices consistently.

As you journey through these pages, pause, reflect and put the lessons into practice. **Remember:** healthy living is not a destination; it is a daily choice.

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CHAPTER ONE: What Does It Mean to Eat Intelligently?

> ***"To eat is a necessity, but to eat intelligently is an art."***
> *François de La Rochefoucauld*

This timeless quote reminds us that while eating is essential for survival, eating wisely is an art and a skill that must be learned, intentionally practised and ultimately embraced as a lifestyle .

Let's break it down:

To Eat Is a Necessity

Eating is one of life's basic necessities. Our bodies require food to provide energy, strengthen the immune system and maintain the proper functioning of every organ. Without food, life cannot be sustained. Hence, as human beings, we are inherently food-dependent, we rely on food for nourishment and life support!

However, simply eating is not enough. The quality, quantity and timing of what we eat profoundly influence our health and overall well-being.

But to Eat Intelligently Is an Art

The second part of the quote moves beyond the act of eating to the wisdom of eating well.

Like every art, intelligent eating requires knowledge, constant practice and discipline. It is cultivated through consistent healthy choices rather than occasional good intentions.

Eating intelligently means recognizing that every meal has consequences, whether positive or negative. The foods we choose can either nourish the body, strengthen the immune system or gradually contribute to poor health and chronic illness.

By describing intelligent eating as an art, François de La Rochefoucauld encourages us to become intentional about our daily food choices. Instead of eating merely to satisfy hunger or cravings, we should eat with purpose, choosing foods based on our bodies' needs and also support a longer, healthier life.

Food possesses an extraordinary ability to heal, restore, protect, energise, beautify and sustain life when consumed wisely.

The encouraging news is that intelligent eating is not a gift reserved for a select few; it is a lifelong skill that anyone can learn.

As you journey through this journal, you will discover practical principles that will empower you to make healthier food choices and enjoy a richer quality of life.

What Is Intelligent Eating?

Intelligent eating is the deliberate practice of choosing foods that nourish the body, prevent disease, support healing, while promoting optimal physical, mental and emotional well-being. It is eating with **knowledge, purpose, discipline and gratitude**.

As an intelligent eater, you do not simply ask:

"What do I feel like eating?"

Instead, you ask:

- What does my body need?
- Will this food nourish me or harm me?
- Does this meal support my long-term health?
- Is this food as close to nature as possible?

These simple questions can transform eating from a daily routine into a powerful act of self-care.

To answer the question: What does it mean to eat intelligently?
To eat intelligently means:

- To eat a balanced diet.
- To eat seasonal foods.
- To eat your food as your medicine.
- To eat in harmony with your body's natural clock.
- To eat the right quantity of food your body needs.
- To prepare food in ways that preserve its nutritional value.
- To take advantage of the **preventive (prophylactic), healing (therapeutic), and healthy ageing (geriatric)** effects of food on your body.

Each of these principles will be explored in greater detail in the chapters that follow.

Benefits of Eating Intelligently

To eat intelligently is one of the greatest investments you can make in your health. Some of the benefits are:

- It improves energy levels.
- It strengthens the immune system.
- It supports a healthy body weight.
- It helps to reduce the risk of diseases.
- It improves mental clarity and concentration.
- It promotes healthy ageing.

Reflect & Journal

Take a moment to reflect on what intelligent eating means to you and how your everyday food choices affect your well-being.

1. What does eating intelligently mean to me?
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
2. What usually influences the foods I choose; hunger, cravings, convenience, emotions, or health?
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
3. Do I see food mainly as something to satisfy hunger, or as nourishment for my body? Why?
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
4. How can I become more intentional about the foods I choose?
   _____
   _____

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_____
_____

5. What do I want my food choices to contribute to my health and well-being?

_____
_____
_____
_____

Today's Action

Practise intentional eating with one meal today.

Before you eat, pause and ask yourself: **Why am I eating this, and what will it do for my body?**

After the meal, take a moment to reflect:

Did I eat simply to satisfy a craving, or did I make a choice that nourished my body?

Write down what you noticed and one thing you would like to remember when making your next food choice.

_____
_____
_____
_____

Scriptural Reference

> "Beloved, I pray that you may prosper in all things and be in health, just as your soul prospers." 3 John 2 (NKJV)

Eat Intelligently Tip

"Don't eat merely to fill your stomach; choose foods that support your body's needs"

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CHAPTER TWO: Eat A Balanced Diet.

To eat intelligently means to eat a balanced diet.
"A balanced diet is not about eating more or less; it is about eating wisely."

Many people think healthy eating means giving up certain foods, spending a lot on food, or following complicated meal plans. But a balanced diet is not about eating less or avoiding the foods you enjoy. It is simply about combining a variety of foods in the right proportion. Your body needs different nutrients which no single food can offer. This is why a balanced diet includes a variety of nutrients from different classes of food, in appropriate proportions, rather than eating too much of one type of food. Eating wisely means learning how to prepare meals that provide the nutrients your body needs without overloading it with too much of a particular group of foods and too little of another. It means giving vegetables, fruits, whole grains or other healthy carbohydrates, proteins, healthy fats, fibre and water their proper place in your meals.

For proper perspective, let's consider the variety of nutrients from the different classes of food:

1. Carbohydrates:
These are energy-giving nutrients. They are the body's main source of energy. Carbohydrates provide the body with energy for everyday activities such as walking, working, learning, exercising and even breathing. The body breaks down carbohydrates into glucose, which cells can use for energy. Examples are whole grains, oats, brown rice, millet, maize, potatoes, sweet potatoes, yam, plantain etc.

2. Proteins
These are body-building nutrients, needed for growth, repair and maintenance of body tissues. Protein helps the body build and repair muscles, skin, blood and other tissues. It is also needed to make enzymes, hormones and other substances essential for normal body functions. Good sources of protein are beans, lentils, peas, eggs, fish, chicken, lean meat, milk, yoghurt, soybeans, nuts, seeds etc.

3. Healthy fats
They are energy-giving and supportive nutrients that provide energy and support the brain, hormones, cells and absorption of vitamins. Fats are an important source of energy and play several vital roles in the body. Sources of healthy fats include avocado, nuts, seeds, olive oil, groundnut oil, oily fish and other plant-based oils. It is important to choose healthy sources and consume fats in appropriate amounts.

4. Vitamins & Minerals

Are protective and regulating nutrients needed for proper body function. Although they are needed in relatively small amounts, but they perform many important functions. They help support the immune system, maintain healthy bones and teeth, support blood formation and help the body's organs and systems function properly. A varied diet provides these nutrients through foods such as vegetables, fruits, beans, whole grains, dairy products, eggs, fish, meat, nuts, seeds etc.

5. Fibre

Is a digestion-supporting nutrient for healthy digestion and overall health. Fibre is a type of carbohydrate that the body does not fully digest. It helps keep the digestive system functioning properly, supports regular bowel movements and can help us feel full for longer period of time. Eating enough fibre is also good for better heart and metabolic health. Good sources of fibre include vegetables, fruits, beans, lentils, whole grains, oats, nuts, chiaseeds, flaxseeds etc..

6. Water

Is a life-sustaining nutrient essential for almost every organ in the body to function. Water is more than a drink; it is essential for life. It keeps the body hydrated, helps transport nutrients and oxygen to cells and tissues. It helps regulate body temperature, lubricate joints, support digestion and also remove waste from the body. Good sources of water include safe drinking water, fruits and vegetables with high water content, milk and other unsweetened fluids.

How It All Works Together

As mentioned earlier, there is no single food that can provide everything the body needs. That is why variety matters**.** A balanced diet brings different foods together so that the nutrients they provide complement one another.

Think of your meals as a team:

Carbohydrates provide energy, proteins build and repair, healthy fats support important body functions, vitamins and minerals help regulate processes, fibre supports digestion and water keeps the body's systems working properly.

Balance is not about making every meal perfect. It is about creating variety and balance across your meals and over time.

Here's a simple guide to illustrate how a balanced diet should look like, it's the **Healthy Eating Plate**.

- **Half of the plate** should be served with colourful vegetables and whole fruits, allowing vegetables to occupy the larger portion.
- **One-quarter** of the plate should be served with whole grains or other healthy carbohydrates.
- **Another one-quarter** of the plate filled with healthy protein and also, a small amount of healthy fats.
- Drink plenty of water throughout the day.



Please Note:
This plate is a guide rather than a rigid rule, always ensure your nutritional needs are considered when preparing your healthy eating plate. Individual nutritional needs vary depending on age, sex, body size, physical activity and health conditions

Fruit, More Than a Snack

It is sometimes argued that fruits should only be eaten as snacks because they may not be filling enough to serve as a meal. But fruit is much more versatile than that. It can be enjoyed as a snack, included in a meal, or blended into a nourishing smoothie to serve as breakfast.

Here is a recipe for a nutritious breakfast smoothie:

1 cup of coconut milk or tigernut milk
1 cup of pineapple chunks
1 handful of spinach or any vegetable of your choice
1 tablespoon of chia seeds
1 teaspoon of healthy plant-based oil
Blend together, served chilled and garnished with some cashew nuts or any nut of your choice.

Get creative with your smoothies by combining different fruits and vegetables that are readily available in your environment.There is no single “best” time to eat fruit. What matters is enjoying a variety of fruits regularly and finding enjoyable ways to include them in your everyday meals and snacks.

Reflect & Journal

Take a moment to reflect on what you have learnt about balanced diet and how your everyday food choices can be improved on.

1. How balanced are my meals on a typical day?
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
2. Which food group do I eat too little of?
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
3. Do I regularly include vegetables and fruits in my meals?
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
4. What one change can I make this week to improve my diet?
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____

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5. How can I make my plate more colourful and nutritious?

_____
_____
_____
_____

Today's Action

Prepare one balanced meal today using the Healthy Eating Plate as your guide.

Take note of how you feel afterwards.

_____
_____
_____
_____

Scriptural Reference

> "Whether therefore ye eat, or drink, or whatsoever ye do, do all to the glory of God." 1 Corinthians 10:31 (KJV)

Eat Intelligently Tip

> *Before eating, look at your plate. If it lacks colour, balance or variety, it is probably lacking important nutrients too.*

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CHAPTER THREE: Eat Seasonal Foods.

To eat intelligently means to eat seasonal food.
"Nature provides the right foods at the right time for the right season."

Nature is one of God's greatest gifts to humanity. It not only provides food but also reveals timeless lessons about healthy living. Every season brings forth fruits, vegetables, grains, and other foods that are naturally suited to that particular time of the year.

These foods are often fresher, richer in nutrients, more flavourful and more affordable because they are harvested at their peak. More importantly, many seasonal foods contain nutrients that help support the body's changing needs.

Unfortunately, modern lifestyles have disconnected many people from nature's rhythm. Because supermarkets make almost every food available throughout the year, many people no longer pay attention to foods in season.

One of the principles of intelligent eating is learning to work with nature rather than against it. When we eat foods during their natural season, we enjoy them at their nutritional best while benefiting from the wisdom built into creation. Every season brings a unique selection of fruits and vegetables. Many seasonal fruits and vegetables naturally provide nutrients that help support the body's changing nutritional needs as the weather changes. For example, during colder or rainy seasons, when illnesses such as colds, flu, coughs and catarrh are often more common, fruits such as oranges, lemons, tangerines, grapefruit, guava, kiwi, pineapple and pawpaw (papaya) are commonly available in many regions. These fruits are excellent sources of vitamin C and antioxidants that support normal immune function and help the body defend itself against seasonal infections.
Likewise, during **hot seasons**, water-rich fruits and vegetables such as watermelon, cucumber, oranges, tomatoes, leafy vegetables and coconut water help replenish fluids lost through sweating while supplying essential vitamins and minerals that support hydration and overall well-being.
Nature seems to know what our bodies need. As the seasons change, so does the variety of foods available to nourish us.



Practical Ways to Eat Seasonal Foods

- Learn which foods are in season in your locality.
- Buy from local markets and farmers.
- Plan meals around seasonal produce.
- Preserve surplus foods by drying or freezing when appropriate.
- Be flexible with recipes based on what is available.
- Teach your family and children to appreciate seasonal eating.

Reflect & Journal

Every region has its own growing seasons. Take a few moments to identify the fresh foods that are naturally available in your neighbourhood.

1. Current Season

Fruits & Vegetables in season

_____

_____

_____

_____

Other seasonal foods (grains, legumes, tubers, etc.)

_____
_____
_____
_____

2. **Next Season**
Fruits & Vegetables I look forward to eating

_____
_____
_____
_____

3. How often do I choose fresh seasonal produce instead of highly processed foods?

_____
_____
_____
_____

4. Which seasonal fruits or vegetables do I enjoy the most?

_____
_____
_____
_____

5. What seasonal food can I intentionally add to my meals this week?

_____
_____
_____
_____

Today's Action

Visit a local market, grocery store, or fruit stand this week. Identify three fruits or vegetables that are currently in season where you live. Purchase at least one of them and include it in one of your meals today.Observe its freshness, flavour and quality. Record your experience in your journal.

_____
_____

_____

_____

Scriptural Reference

"To everything there is a season, and a time for every purpose under heaven."
Ecclesiastes 3:1 (NKJV)

Eat Intelligently Tip

Let the seasons shape your plate and let nature become one of your greatest partners in building vibrant health.

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CHAPTER FOUR: Eat Your Food As Your Medicine

To eat intelligently means to eat your food as your medicine
'Eat your food as medicine, so that you will not eat your medicine as food'
Ancient Proverb This is a wise saying!

God has provided an abundance of natural foods that contain vitamins, minerals, fibre, antioxidants and other beneficial compounds that help protect the body and support its natural ability to repair and restore itself. When we intentionally choose these wholesome foods, we allow them to support our health and reduce our risk of many lifestyle-related diseases.

Eating your food as medicine simply means making wise food choices every day so that your meals become part of your strategy for maintaining good health and supporting your body's natural healing process.

How Do You Eat Your Food As Medicine?

To eat your food as medicine is to recognise that what you put on your plate can either support your health or work against it. Food is more than something that fills the stomach; it provides the nutrients the body needs to function, repair itself and maintain good health.

This means being intentional about the foods you choose. Rather than waiting until a health problem develops before paying attention to your diet, make healthy food choices part of your everyday life.

For example, if you want to support your heart health, you can regularly include foods such as oats, leafy vegetables, garlic, flaxseeds, beetroot, berries, bananas, hibiscus, sunflower seeds, sweet potatoes, pomegranates, pistachios and avocado as part of a balanced diet.

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The same principle applies when someone is already dealing with a health condition. Food may not replace medical treatment, but it can play an important supporting role in the healing and recovery process. For some health conditions, improving the quality of the diet and making other healthy lifestyle changes can make a significant difference to overall health and, in some cases, improve how well the body responds to treatment.

Take type 2 diabetes, for example. Medication may be necessary for some people, but medication alone does not remove the importance of healthy eating, physical activity, adequate sleep, stress management and healthy weight management. Making vegetables, whole grains, legumes and other nourishing foods a regular part of the diet can support better overall metabolic health. Foods such as leafy vegetables, broccoli, mushrooms, cucumber, onions, bell peppers, tomatoes and other colourful vegetables can contribute valuable fibre, vitamins, minerals and protective plant compounds to the diet. Moringa leaves can also be used as a nutrient-rich food, where available.



This is what it means to eat your food as medicine. I am not suggesting that you throw away your medication or stop seeking medical care. Rather, I am encouraging you to understand that your daily food choices are part of your health care too.

Do not wait until illness forces you to change your diet. Let your everyday meals become part of your health-conscious lifestyle. Choose foods that nourish you, support your body's normal functions and complement appropriate medical care when treatment is needed.

Every meal should have a purpose. Instead of asking only, *"Will this satisfy my hunger?"* also ask, *"How will this meal benefit my health?"*

Practical Ways to Eat Your Food as Medicine

- Include a variety of colourful fruits and vegetables in your daily meals.
- Eat more whole, natural foods and reduce your intake of highly-processed foods.
- Make herbs and spices such as garlic, ginger, turmeric, moringa, scent leaf, cloves,oregano etc regular ingredients in your recipes, where appropriate.
- Drink adequate water every day.
- Learn which foods provide nutritional support for your specific health needs.

Reflect & Journal

Take a moment to reflect on these questions and journal as you take conscious effort towards preventing or treating any ailment.

1. Do I think about the nutritional value of my meals before I eat?

   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____

2. Which foods in my current diet are promoting good health and which ones are working against it?

   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____

3. Are there any health conditions I could better support through healthier food choices?

   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____

4. What one change will I make this week to begin eating my food as medicine?

   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____

Today's Action

- Add at least one fruit and two vegetables to your meals every day this week.
- Replace one processed snack with a natural, wholesome alternative.
- Identify foods that support your current health needs and include them in your weekly meal plan.

Scriptural Reference

……their fruit will serve for food and their leaves for healing." Ezekiel 47:12 (NIV)

Eat Intelligently Tip

Every meal is either fighting a disease or feeding a disease.

CHAPTER FIVE: Eat In Harmony With Your Body's Clock

To eat intelligently means to eat in harmony with your body's clock
"Your body works best when you work with it, not against it." **Anonymous**

This quote reminds us that our bodies were intelligently designed to function according to natural rhythms and a God-given timetable. When we respect these rhythms by eating at appropriate times, getting adequate rest, exercising regularly, and making wise food choices, we support our body's ability to function at its best. However, when we consistently ignore them, we may experience fatigue, poor digestion, weight gain and other health challenges. One of the simplest ways to work *with* your body rather than *against* it is to eat in harmony with its natural clock.

What Does It Mean to Eat in Harmony with Your Body's Clock?

Eating intelligently is not only about choosing the right foods; it is also about eating them at the right time.
God designed our bodies with an internal biological clock; a natural timing system that regulates when we sleep, wake, digest food and produce important hormones. Scientists refer to this natural timing system as the **circadian rhythm**. When we eat in harmony with this rhythm, our bodies are generally better able to digest food, utilize nutrients, support the body's natural healing and repair processes.

However, irregular meal times, skipping meals, or eating heavy meals late at night can interfere with these natural rhythms and place unnecessary stress on the body.

Simply put, to eat intelligently is to eat the right foods at the right time, while allowing your body enough time to digest, rest and restore itself.

Why Meal Timing Matters

Just as there is a proper time to sleep, to work and rest, there is also a proper time to eat. During the day, your body is naturally more prepared to digest and utilize food for energy. As evening approaches, digestion gradually slows as the body prepares for rest and overnight repair. Working with this natural rhythm can improve digestion, stabilize blood sugar, support healthy weight management, enhance sleep quality and promote overall well-being as discussed earlier.
Small changes in meal timing, when practised consistently, can make a significant difference to your health.

Principles for Eating in Harmony with Your Body's Clock

1. Begin Your Day with Warm Water Therapy

Begin your day with warm water or room-temperature water. After several hours of sleep, your body wakes up slightly dehydrated. Drinking one or two glasses of water immediately after waking helps rehydrate the body, gently stimulates digestion, supports bowel movement and prepares the digestive system for the day's meals. Many people prefer warm water because it is soothing and may encourage digestive activity, while others are more comfortable with room-temperature water. The most important habit is to start your day by rehydrating your body before breakfast. Allow about 40 to 60 minutes before eating breakfast. During this time, you may pray, exercise lightly, meditate, or prepare for the day.

2. Eat a Nourishing Breakfast

Breakfast breaks the overnight fast and provides the energy your body needs to function effectively. A healthy breakfast helps activate your metabolism, improve concentration and replenish nutrients used during the night. If there is one meal of the day that should not be skipped, it is Breakfast, except when fasting.Choose wholesome foods such as fruits, whole grains, eggs, yoghurt, nuts, seeds, or other nutrient-rich foods instead of highly processed or sugary meals.

3. Eat Your Main Meal Earlier in the Day

Your digestive system and metabolism are generally more active during the morning and afternoon. This makes breakfast and lunch the best times for more substantial meals. As the day progresses, reduce the quantity of food and choose lighter meals that are easier to digest.

4. Avoid Late-Night Eating

Eating too close to bedtime gives your digestive system extra work when it should be preparing for rest. Late-night eating has been associated with poor digestion, disturbed sleep, weight gain, acid reflux and impaired blood sugar regulation. Whenever possible, finish your evening meal at least two to three hours before bedtime.

5. Eat Balanced Meals Throughout the Day

Regardless of the time of the day, prioritize consuming well-balanced meals that include a variety of nutrients.

Focus on whole foods, including fruits, vegetables, lean proteins, whole grains and healthy fats. By doing so, you are providing your body with the nutrients it needs throughout the day.

It's important to note that individual variations exist and what works for one person may not work for another. Paying attention to your body's signals, energy levels and overall well-being can help you determine the eating pattern that works best for you.

However, every meal should be thoughtfully planned, rather than relying on readily available junk food that may fill your stomach but lacks the nourishment your body needs. Don't forget **Healthy Eating Plate** as discussed in chapter two.

Balanced meals provide sustained energy, reduce unhealthy cravings and help your body function at its best.

6. Listen to Your Body

As discussed above, healthy eating principles apply to everyone, but each person's needs are unique. Pay attention to your body's hunger and fullness signals. Learn to distinguish genuine hunger from eating out of boredom, stress or habit. Developing this awareness helps you establish an eating routine that supports your health and lifestyle.

Daily Eating Rhythm: Working with Your Body's Clock

Time	Activity	Purpose
Immediately After Waking	**Warm Water Therapy**	Rehydrates the body after the overnight fast, stimulates digestion and prepares the digestive system for food.
40–60 Minutes Later	**Nutritious Breakfast**	Breaks the overnight fast, activates metabolism, and provides energy for the day.

Time	Activity	Purpose
12:00–2:00 PM	**Lunch (Main Meal)**	Supplies sustained energy when digestion and metabolism are most active.
3:00–4:00 PM (Optional)	**Healthy Snack**	Helps maintain energy levels and prevents overeating later in the day.
6:00–7:30 PM	**Light Dinner**	Supports healthy digestion and allows the body to prepare for rest.
After Dinner	**Allow Your Body to Rest**	Avoid heavy meals or frequent snacking so the digestive system can rest overnight.

Please Note:
These are general guidelines, not rigid rules. Your routine may vary depending on your age, work schedule, health condition and lifestyle. The goal is to develop a consistent eating pattern that works in harmony with your body's natural rhythm.

Reflect & Journal

Take a few moments to evaluate your eating routine.

1. Do I begin each day with warm water therapy?
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____
2. Do I eat breakfast regularly?
   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____

BIKOL IDOL

3. Do I make lunch my main meal whenever possible?

   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____

4. How often do I eat late at night?

   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____

5. What one change can I make this week to better align my eating with my body's natural rhythm?

   _____
   _____
   _____
   _____

Today's Action

Today, I will intentionally:

- Eat my meals at consistent times.
- Start my day with a nourishing breakfast.
- Make my main meals earlier in the day whenever possible.
- Finish dinner at least **2–3 hours before bedtime**.
- Avoid unnecessary late-night snacking.

Scriptural Reference

*"Listen, my son, and be wise, and set your heart on the right path."*Proverbs 23:19

Eat Intelligently Tip

Your body thrives on rhythm. Eat consistently, nourish yourself early in the day and give your digestive system enough time to rest before bedtime.

BUKOLA IDOWU

CHAPTER SIX: Portion Control

To eat intelligently means to eat only the quantity of food your body needs at every mealtime.

"Enough is as good as a feast." Old English Proverb

Healthy eating is not only about what you eat, when you eat but also how much you eat. Many people assume that if a food is healthy, they can eat as much of it as they like. However, even nutritious foods can become unhealthy when consumed in excess. On the other hand, eating too little can deprive your body of the nutrients and energy it needs to function properly.

Eating intelligently means giving your body the right amount of food at the right time, enough to nourish it without overloading it or starving it.This is what is referred to as **portion control** in healthy eating habits.

God designed our bodies with natural hunger and fullness signals. Learning to recognise and respect these signals is one of the simplest ways to maintain good health.

What Is Portion Control?

Portion control is the practice of eating only the quantity of food your body needs at each meal. It is not about starving yourself, skipping meals, or following restrictive diets. Rather, it is about eating enough to meet your body's nutritional needs without overeating. Just as it is harmful to overeat, it is equally harmful to undereat.

Do not starve your cells!

Every cell in your body depends on nutrients from the food you eat to produce energy, repair tissues, support the immune system and most importantly, help keep your organs functioning properly. Healthy eating is about balance, not excess and not deprivation.

Why Portion Sizes Differ

As mentioned earlier in Chapter Two, that our nutritional needs differ from person to person based on factors such as age, sex, body size, physical activity level, health conditions, pregnancy and breastfeeding. It is therefore important to understand that the amount of food we need will also vary from one person to another. There is no single portion size that is suitable for everyone.

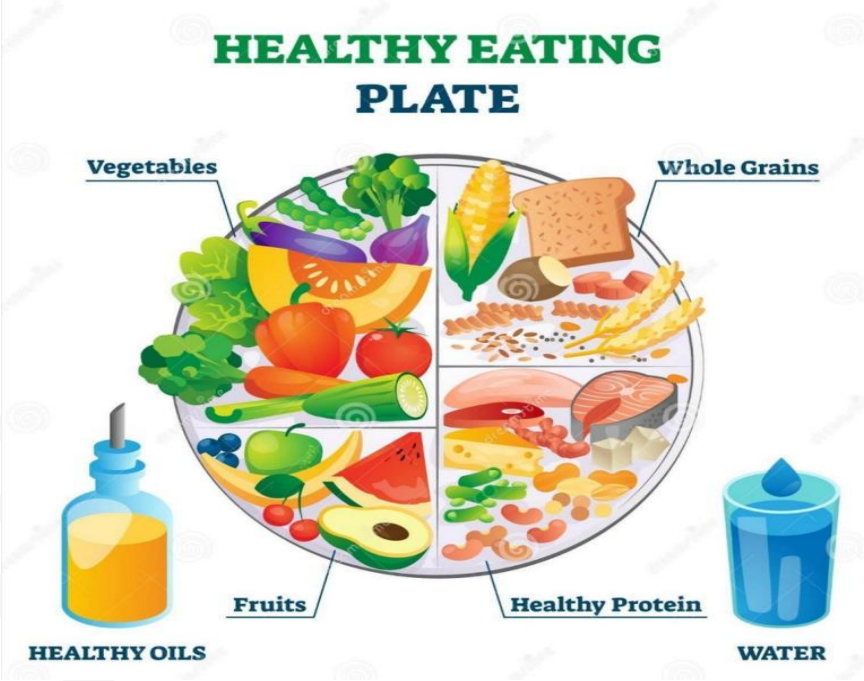
Generally, men may require more calories than women because they often have greater muscle mass and higher energy needs. Likewise, growing children, pregnant women and highly active individuals may require different portion sizes.

The goal is not to compare your plate with someone else's but to nourish your own body appropriately.

Healthy Eating Plate vs Portion Control

It is important to understand the difference.

A **Healthy Eating Plate** teaches **what** your meal should contain; a balance of vegetables, fruits, whole grains, healthy proteins and healthy fats.
Portion Control, on the other hand, teaches **how much** of those foods your body needs. That is, to say:
Healthy Eating Plate = What to eat
Portion Control = How much to eat
Both principles work together to help you eat intelligently.



Portion Control Guide

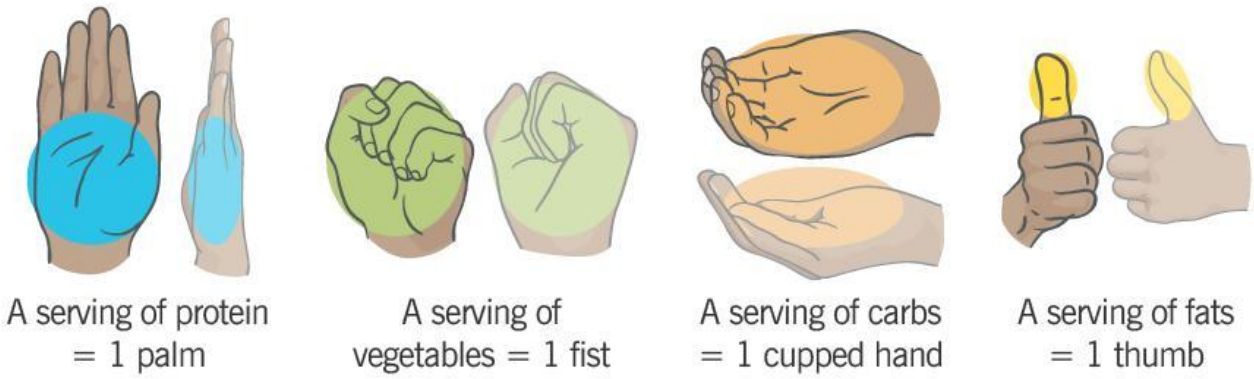
You do not need a food scale to determine the right amount of food for each meal. Just as the Healthy Eating Plate guides us on what to eat, the simple Hand Portion Guide helps us estimate how much to eat.

Hand Portion Guide can help you estimate appropriate portions using your hand as a simple measuring guide. Your hands are one of the easiest tools for estimating portions because they are generally proportional to your body size.

- **Palm:** A portion of **protein-rich foods** such as fish, chicken, beans, eggs, or tofu should be approximately the size of your palm.
- **Fist:** A portion of **vegetables or fruits** should be approximately the size of your fist.
- **Cupped Hand:** A portion of **whole grains and other healthy carbohydrate foods**, such as rice, yam, sweet potato, or pasta, should fit into your cupped hand.
- **Thumb:** A portion of **healthy fats**, such as olive oil, peanut butter, avocado, or nuts, should be approximately the size of your thumb.

This method makes portion control practical whether you are eating at home, at work, or in a restaurant.

Here is an illustration of the hand portion guide



Please note
A balanced plate looks similar for both men and women, but the serving sizes or quantity may differ according to individual energy needs.

Recognising Fullness

One of the best ways to practise portion control is to pay attention to your body's natural hunger and fullness signals. Signs that you have probably eaten enough:

- You no longer feel hungry.
- You feel comfortably satisfied, not stuffed.
- You can still move around comfortably after eating.
- You do not feel excessively heavy or uncomfortable.

A helpful habit is to stop eating when you feel comfortably satisfied rather than waiting until you are completely full. Eating slowly gives your body time to recognise fullness and can help prevent overeating.

Practical Portion-Control Habits

- Eat slowly and chew your food thoroughly.
- Avoid eating while watching television or scrolling through your phone.
- Serve your meals on an appropriate-sized plate.
- Avoid eating directly from large packets or containers; serve yourself an appropriate portion instead.
- Distinguish physical hunger from emotional cravings.
- Pay attention to your portion size before going back for more.

Reflect & Journal

1. Do I usually stop eating when I am comfortably satisfied or only when I feel very full?

_____
_____
_____
_____

2. Which eating habit most often causes me to overeat?

_____
_____

BLKOUT

_____

_____

3. What practical step will I take this week to improve my portion control?

_____

_____

_____

_____

Today's Action

At your next meal: Serve yourself a sensible portion.
Eat slowly. Chew thoroughly.
Pause halfway through your meal and ask yourself, *"Am I still hungry?"* Stop eating when you feel comfortably satisfied. Observe how you feel one hour later.

_____

_____

_____

_____

Scriptural Reference

> *"If you find honey, eat just enough—too much of it, and you will vomit."***Proverbs 25:16 (NIV)**

Eat Intelligently Tip

> Don't loosen your belt whenever it's mealtime, you are more likely to overeat!

BUKOLADOW

CHAPTER SEVEN: Preserve the Goodness in Your Food

To eat intelligently means to Preserve the Goodness in Your Food
"The closer your food is to its natural state, the more likely it is to nourish your body."

Nature provides food rich in vitamins, minerals, fibre, healthy fats, antioxidants and other nutrients that nourish, protect and sustain life. However, the way we process and cook our food can either preserve these nutrients or diminish them.

Eating intelligently means choosing preparation methods that retain as much of the natural goodness in our food as possible. While cooking is often necessary for safety and easier digestion, excessive processing and overcooking can reduce the nutritional value of some foods.

The goal is not to avoid food processing or preparation but to prepare food wisely and keep it as close as possible to the way nature intended

What Does It Mean to Preserve the Goodness of Your Food?

Preserving the goodness of your food means handling, processing and cooking your food in ways that ensure the nutrients are not unnecessarily damaged or lost before the food is served.

Here is a simple way to illustrate this:

FARM → KITCHEN

FARM → FACTORY → KITCHEN

Is your food going from the farm to your kitchen, or from the farm to the factory and then to your kitchen?

The journey food takes before it reaches your plate can affect its nutritional quality. Generally, the fewer unnecessary processing steps food goes through, the easier it is to retain many of its natural nutrients and beneficial components.

Think about fresh vegetables bought from the market and taken home for washing, cutting and simple cooking. They have gone through relatively little processing. Much of their natural fibre, vitamins, minerals and other beneficial substances can be retained, especially when they are handled properly and not overcooked.

Now compare this with a food that travels from the farm to a factory before reaching your kitchen. It may go through several stages of milling, refining, heating, drying, canning, or other forms of processing. Ingredients may also be added to improve taste, colour, texture, appearance, or shelf life, including preservatives, flavourings, sweeteners and other additives. Some of these ingredients may have useful purposes and are permitted for use in foods, but the more ingredients and processing a food undergoes, the further it can move from its original form.

Processing can also affect nutrients. Prolonged heating, exposure to water or light and certain refining processes can reduce some vitamins and other beneficial components. On the other hand, some methods of processing, such as freezing, fermentation, or appropriate cooking, can help preserve food, improve safety, or make certain nutrients easier for the body to use.

This is where the intelligent eater makes a conscious choice. You do not have to completely avoid processed food, sometimes it is convenient, affordable, available, or simply unavoidable. The goal is to make less processed, natural foods the larger part of your diet and highly processed foods the smaller part.

In simple terms: eat more food that looks like what nature provided and less food that has been extensively changed from its original form. When processed foods are unavoidable, choose them thoughtfully, read the ingredients and where possible, select options with fewer unnecessary additions.

The intelligent eater does not eat perfectly; the intelligent eater eats consciously. The aim is not fear or restriction, but making better choices more often.

In my view, food that travels from farm to kitchen is ‘’**Real Food’’.** When Food travels from farm to factory then to the kitchen, excessive processing can turn it into what I call **“Foodless Food”** Food that fills the stomach but may offer less of the natural nourishment the body needs.

Real Food versus Foodless Food





'Real' Food	**'Foodless' Food**
Choose more foods like these:	Reduce foods such as:
Fresh fruits	Sugary drinks
Fresh vegetables	Candy and sweets
Beans and legumes	Packaged snacks
Whole grains	Instant noodles
Nuts and seeds	Sugary breakfast cereals
Eggs	Processed meats
Fresh fish	Cookies and pastries
Fresh herbs	Highly processed convenience meals

Bringing fresh food home is only part of the journey.

Now, How Do I Preserve Food Nutrients At Home?

Eating intelligently therefore means paying attention not only to *what* we eat, but also to *how we handle it before it gets to our plate*.

1. Choose Cooking Methods That Preserve Nutrients

Choose cooking methods that help retain as much of the food's natural goodness as possible. Good options include:

I. **Steaming**: is cooking with moist heat. It helps vegetables retain their texture and can reduce the amount of nutrients lost into cooking water.

II. **Light stir-frying** : is a quick cooking method where food is cooked over moderate to high heat for a short time, with little amount of oil, little water may also be added. The food is usually cut into small pieces and stirred or tossed continuously so it cooks evenly. Because the cooking time is short and little water is used, it can help retain texture and nutrients.

III. **Baking** usually refers to cooking food with hot air in an enclosed oven, often at a moderate temperature. It is commonly used for bread, cakes, casseroles, vegetables, fish and similar foods.

IV. Roasting: is cooking food with dry, relatively high heat, often to develop browning and a deeper flavour. It is commonly used for vegetables, meat, poultry and some fruits.

V. Grilling: is cooking food with direct heat, usually over a grill or open flame. It requires little or no added water and can cook food relatively quickly. Avoid excessive burning or blackening of food during grilling, as heavily charred food is not good for regular consumption.

VI. Pressure Cooking: is cooking food in a sealed pot under pressure, which raises the temperature and allows food to cook faster. The shorter cooking time can help reduce some nutrient losses associated with prolonged cooking.

VII. Boiling: is cooking food by immersing it in boiling water. While boiling is a simple and useful cooking method, some water-soluble nutrients can move into the cooking water. Cook for only as long as necessary and, where appropriate, use the cooking water in soups or sauces rather than discarding it.

2. Store Food According to What It Needs

Not every food should be stored in the same way. Most fresh fruits and vegetables have specific storage needs and proper storage helps maintain freshness, quality and safety.

For example, potatoes, sweet potatoes, dry onions and bananas are among the foods that are generally better kept in a cool, dry place rather than in the refrigerator.

On the other hand, many leafy vegetables and other perishable produce should be refrigerated to slow spoilage. Keep your refrigerator at about 4°C (40°F) or below for food safety.

3. Do Not Wash Everything Too Early

It may seem convenient to wash all your fruits and vegetables immediately after shopping, but storing some produce while wet can encourage spoilage. Where appropriate, wash produce shortly before use and keep it dry during storage.

When you wash vegetables before cooking, handle them gently and avoid soaking them unnecessarily for long periods. Some water-soluble nutrients can move into the water, particularly during prolonged soaking or cooking.

4. Keep Cut Fruits and Vegetables Properly Stored

Once fruits and vegetables are cut, more of their inner surfaces are exposed to air, moisture and possible contamination. Cut only what you need when practical.

If you have leftovers, place them in a clean, covered container and refrigerate them promptly. Cooked leftovers should generally be used within 3–4 days or frozen for longer storage.

5. Do Not Overcook Your Vegetables

One of the simplest kitchen habits you can adopt is to cook vegetables until they are just tender rather than cooking them until they become very soft and mushy.

Prolonged cooking, especially in large amounts of water, can reduce some sensitive nutrients. For vegetables that you intend to freeze, proper blanching followed by quick cooling helps preserve quality and colour; however, over-blanching can increase nutrient loss.

6. Use Freezing Wisely

Freezing can be a useful way to preserve seasonal fruits and vegetables when you have more than you can consume immediately. Properly frozen food can retain much of its nutritional value while extending its usable life.

If you are freezing many fresh vegetables, blanching them first is generally recommended because it helps preserve their quality and stops enzymes that can affect colour, flavour and texture.

7. Protect Food from Excessive Heat, Light, Air and Moisture

Some nutrients are sensitive to heat, light, air and prolonged exposure to water. This is one reason why proper storage and simple preparation matter.

Keep dry foods in clean, dry, airtight containers where appropriate, and store them away from excessive heat and direct sunlight. This can help maintain their quality and protect them from moisture, insects and spoilage.

A Few Simple Kitchen Hacks to Remember

- **Buy what you can reasonably consume.**
  Do not buy large quantities of fresh produce simply because they are available cheaply, if much of it will end up spoiled.
- **Use older produce first.**
  Keep newly purchased items behind older ones so that older food is used first.
- **Keep your refrigerator organised.**
  Store foods properly and avoid overcrowding so that cold air can circulate.
- **Do not keep cut food exposed.**
  Cover it and refrigerate it promptly when refrigeration is required.
- **Cook only what you need.**
  Preparing excessive quantities can lead to repeated reheating and unnecessary food waste.
- **Use cooking water wisely.**
  When vegetables are boiled, some nutrients may move into the water. Where appropriate, use the cooking water in soups or sauces rather than simply throwing it away.

Reflect & Journal

1. Looking at my meals this week, do they contain more foods from the farm or from the factory?

_____
_____
_____
_____

2. Which highly processed food can I replace with a fresher alternative?

_____
_____

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_____
_____

3. What healthier cooking method will I intentionally practise more often?

_____
_____
_____
_____

4. How will I preserve the nutrients in my food at home?

_____
_____
_____
_____

Today's Action

Put one simple food-preservation habit into practice today. Choose one food in your kitchen and decide how best to store, wash, cut, or cook it to help preserve its nutrients and freshness.
Write down one kitchen hack you learned today and one change you will practise from now on.

_____
_____
_____
_____

Scriptural Reference

"He satisfies you with good things, so that your youth is renewed like the eagle's."

Eat Intelligently Tip

BUYER BEWARE

The food industry invests heavily in marketing processed foods because they can be highly profitable. This makes it even more important for us to look beyond the advertising and ask: *Is this truly nourishing food, or is it "foodless food"*

Chapter 8: Food Beyond Nutrition

> **To eat intelligently is to take advantage of the prophylactic, therapeutic, cosmetic and geriatric effects of food on your body.**

Prophylactic refers to the role of food in disease prevention.
Therapeutic refers to the role of food in supporting the healing and recovery process.
Cosmetic refers to the role of food in promoting healthy skin, hair, nails and overall beauty.
Geriatric refers to the role of nutrition in promoting healthy ageing .

> ***"The food you eat can be either the safest and most powerful form of medicine or the slowest form of poison." Ann Wigmore***

Every day, the food you choose is doing something inside your body. It is either nourishing you or failing to provide the nutrients your body needs for good health.

Eating intelligently means understanding that food is more than something to fill your stomach, it is one of God's gifts for promoting health and well-being. While food is not a substitute for appropriate medical care, it plays a vital role in supporting the body's normal functions, helping to prevent disease, supporting recovery from illness and promoting healthy ageing.

1. Food for Disease Prevention (Prophylactic)

The word **prophylactic** simply means **preventing disease before it occurs**. Many natural foods, such as leafy green vegetables, citrus fruits, berries, beans and legumes, whole grains, nuts and seeds contain vitamins, minerals, antioxidants, fibre and other protective compounds that help reduce the risk of many lifestyle-related diseases when eaten regularly as part of a balanced diet.
Here are some foods that can be incorporated into our daily meals to prevent certain health conditions:

- **To help maintain healthy blood pressure:**
  Include foods such as bananas, oranges, spinach, kale, beetroot, sweet potatoes,

avocados, beans, oats, and low-fat yoghurt in your diet. These foods are rich in nutrients such as potassium, magnesium, calcium, and fibre, which support healthy blood pressure.

- **To support heart health:**
  eat foods rich in healthy fats, fibre and antioxidants. Examples are oats, fatty fish (salmon, sardines and mackerel), avocados, olive oil, walnuts, almonds, flax seeds, chia seeds, beans and leafy green vegetables.
- **To help maintain healthy blood sugar levels:**
  choose fibre-rich, low-glycemic foods such as whole grains, oats, brown rice, beans, lentils, chickpeas, vegetables, apples, berries, pears, nuts, seeds and unsweetened yoghurt.
- **To support healthy weight management:**
  include foods that are naturally high in fibre, protein and water. Such as vegetables, fruits, beans, lentils, oats, whole grains, eggs, fish, skinless chicken and greek yoghurt. These foods help you feel full for longer and reduce the tendency to overeat.
- **To help protect the body against certain cancers:**
  eat a variety of colourful fruits and vegetables, including berries, tomatoes, broccoli, cabbage, cauliflower, carrots, leafy green vegetables, garlic, onions, citrus fruits, beans, whole grains and green tea. These foods are rich in antioxidants and phytochemicals that help protect body cells from damage.
  It is important to remember that no single food can prevent disease. Rather, it is the consistent habit of eating a balanced diet rich in wholesome foods, together with regular exercise, adequate sleep, proper hydration and other healthy lifestyle practices, that offers the greatest protection against many chronic diseases.
  Prevention is always better than cure.
  By making wise food choices today, you are investing in a healthier tomorrow.

2. Food for Healing (Therapeutic)

Therapeutic refers to the healing and restorative effects of food. While food should never replace professional medical care, proper nutrition supports the body's remarkable healing processes. During illness, injury, or recovery, the body requires additional nutrients to repair damaged tissues, fight infections, restore strength and regain normal function. The following nutrients and foods can support the body's healing process:

- **Foods rich in protein** help build and repair damaged tissues, promote wound healing and maintain healthy muscles. Examples are fish, chicken, eggs, beans, lentils, lean meat, tofu, greek yoghurt, milk, nuts etc.
- **Foods rich in vitamin C** support wound healing, strengthen the immune system and help the body produce collagen, an essential protein needed for healthy skin, blood vessels and connective tissues. Examples are oranges, guava, lemons, strawberries, kiwi, bell peppers, broccoli, tomatoes etc.
- **Foods rich in iron** help the body produce healthy red blood cells, which transport oxygen to every part of the body. Adequate oxygen is essential for tissue repair and recovery.
  Examples are lean red meat, liver, beans, lentils, spinach, pumpkin seeds, fortified cereals, dark green leafy vegetables etc.
- **Probiotic foods** help restore the balance of good bacteria in the gut, improving digestion, strengthening immunity and supporting recovery, especially after a course of antibiotics.
  Examples are yoghurt with live cultures, kefir, fermented vegetables (such as sauerkraut and kimchi) and other naturally fermented foods.
- **Foods rich in omega-3 fatty acids** help reduce inflammation and support the healing of the heart, brain and joints. Examples are salmon, sardines, mackerel, trout, walnuts, flaxseeds, chia seeds, soybeans etc.
- **Foods rich in zinc** play an important role in wound healing, tissue repair and immune function, helping the body recover more effectively from illness and injury.
  Examples are pumpkin seeds, beans, chickpeas, beef, seafood, nuts, whole grains etc.

Good nutrition provides your body with the building blocks it needs to repair, recover and function at its best. Every wholesome meal contributes to the healing process and supports your body's remarkable ability to restore itself.

> **Always remember this:**
> Food supports the body's natural healing process, but it should complement, not replace appropriate medical care and treatment when needed.

3. Food for Healthy Beauty (Cosmetic)

Foods rich in vitamins A, C and E, healthy fats, antioxidants and adequate water help nourish the body from the inside out. For example:

- **Vitamin A** (found in carrots, sweet potatoes, spinach and mangoes) supports healthy skin and vision.
- **Vitamin C** (found in oranges, guava, strawberries, bell peppers, and broccoli) helps the body produce collagen, which keeps the skin firm and aids wound healing.
- **Vitamin E** (found in almonds, sunflower seeds, avocados, and spinach) helps protect skin cells from damage.
- **Healthy fats** (from avocados, nuts, seeds, olive oil and fatty fish) keep the skin soft and moisturised while
- **Antioxidants** (found in berries, tomatoes, leafy greens and green tea) help protect the body from damage caused by harmful free radicals.
- **Drinking enough water** keeps the skin hydrated and supports the proper functioning of every cell in the body. Healthy, glowing skin starts from within!

4. Food for Healthy Ageing (Geriatric)

Geriatric refers to promoting health as we grow older. Although ageing is a natural part of life, healthy eating can help you remain active, energetic and independent for longer.

Certain foods have anti-ageing properties. Regularly including these foods in your diet can help you remain active, healthy and agile as you grow older. Such foods are rich in antioxidants, healthy fats, lean proteins, calcium, vitamin D and fibre. Examples are berries, leafy green vegetables, fatty fish (such as salmon and sardines), eggs, beans, lentils, yoghurt, milk, cheese, almonds, walnuts, chia seeds, flaxseeds, oats, whole grains etc.

For Better Application
Here is a simple guide to help you choose foods that support healthy ageing:

- For Healthy Bones: Include yoghurt, cheese, sardines (with edible bones), fortified plant-based milk and leafy green vegetables in your daily meals.
- For Strong Muscles: Eat eggs, fish, chicken, beans, lentils, tofu and greek yoghurt regularly.
- For Brain Function: Include fatty fish, walnuts, flaxseeds, chia seeds, blueberries and eggs in your diet.
- For Healthy Eyesight: Eat carrots, spinach, kale, sweet potatoes, mangoes and eggs regularly.
- For a Strong Immune System: Include citrus fruits, guava, bell peppers, broccoli, garlic, ginger and yoghurt in your meals.

- For Heart Health: Choose oats, avocados, olive oil, nuts, seeds, beans and fatty fish as part of your regular diet.

Growing older is inevitable, but healthy ageing is greatly influenced by the food choices and lifestyle habits we practise every day.
Food Is an Investment in Your Future

Every meal is making a contribution to your future health. Healthy eating is not a one-time event but a lifelong investment. The benefits of wise food choices accumulate over months and years, helping you enjoy a healthier, stronger and more productive life.

Reflect & Journal

1. Which of the four benefits of food do I appreciate the most and why?

_____
_____
_____
_____

2. What changes can I make to allow my food to work more effectively for my health?

_____
_____
_____
_____

3. Is my daily diet helping to prevent disease and promote long-term health?

_____
_____
_____
_____

Today's Action

Choose one food today that supports each of the four functions of food:
One food for disease prevention.

One food that supports healing.
One food that promotes healthy skin and body.
One food that supports healthy ageing.

Enjoy them with gratitude, knowing that every healthy choice is an investment in your future.

Scriptural Reference

> *"Beloved, I pray that you may prosper in all things and be in health, just as your soul prospers."* **3 John 1:2 (NKJV)**

Eat Intelligently Tip

> Choose foods that protect, nourish, heal, beautify and strengthen you for years to come.

BUKOLA IDOWU

Chapter 9: Twenty Effects Of Food On The Human Body

Every Meal Is an Opportunity to Let Your Food Work *For* You Rather Than *Against* You

So far, we have explored the importance of a balanced diet, appropriate portion sizes and proper meal timing. These are essential aspects of eating intelligently, but there is another important question we need to consider:

What happens inside the body when we eat?

Different foods interact with the body in different ways. Some nourish and strengthen, some protect and support, while others may provide specific benefits to various organs of the body. To deepen our understanding of intelligent eating, let us now examine twenty ways the foods we eat can affect and support our body

1. CALMING EFFECT

There are certain foods that can help calm your nerves when you are agitated or nervous and help you relax. These types of foods provide a steady release of glucose into the bloodstream, which can help stabilize mood and promote relaxation. They may help reduce anxiety and support overall mental health. Some contain **precursors** (that is, building blocks for the production of certain substances in the body) involved in the synthesis of substances that support relaxation and sleep. For example, **tryptophan** is an amino acid that the body uses to produce serotonin and melatonin. Serotonin is a neurotransmitter that contributes to feelings of well-being and helps regulate mood.

Examples of food in this category are:

(a) Whole grains such as oats, brown rice, quinoa, fonio.
(b) Legumes such as beans, lentils, chickpeas.
(c) Poultry products such as chicken, turkey, eggs.
(d) Fish such as salmon, mackerel and sardines, which are rich in omega-3 fatty acids.
(e) Dairy products such as milk, yoghurt and cheese.
(f) Nuts and seeds such as almonds, walnuts, flaxseeds, chia seeds.
(g) Green vegetables such as spinach, lettuce and kale.

(h) Fruits such as blueberries, strawberries, raspberries, apples.
Others include**:** dark chocolate, green tea etc.

2. SEDATIVE EFFECT

These types of food can provide nutrients, in some cases, naturally occurring compounds that may support the body's production of melatonin, the hormone that helps regulate sleep and the sleep-wake cycle. These foods may help promote relaxation and support better sleep quality, making it easier for some people to fall asleep.
Examples of foods in this category are:
(a) Fruits such as bananas, cherries.
(b) Nuts such as almonds, walnuts, cashews.
(c) Leafy green vegetables such as spinach, kale, lettuce, watercress.
(d) Whole grains such as oats, fonio,quinoa, brown rice.
(e) Herbal teas such as chamomile tea, lavender tea, passionflower tea.
(f) Warm milk, as mentioned earlier.

3. DIURETIC EFFECT

There are certain foods, herbs and beverages that may promote increased urine production in the body. This diuretic effect can help the body eliminate excess fluid and support healthy fluid balance. Increased urination also supports the body's natural process of removing certain water-soluble waste products through the kidneys. Some diuretic foods are also naturally rich in water and nutrients, making them useful additions to a healthy diet. When included appropriately, they may support healthy kidney function, circulation and fluid balance.
Examples of fruits, herbs and spices that may exert a diuretic effect include:
(a) Fruits such as cucumber, watermelon, lemon.
(b) Herbs: parsley, dandelion, nettle, horsetail, green tea,hibiscus, celery leaf etc.
(c) Spice such as ginger, cumin,fennel,cinnamon, black pepper.

4. ASTRINGENT EFFECT

There are certain foods that have astringent properties. These foods can have a drying or contracting effect on body tissues and often leave a dry or puckering sensation in the mouth, particularly because of their tannin content. Astringent foods may help tone and tighten tissues, support healthy digestion and provide antioxidant benefits.

Some also contain compounds with antimicrobial properties that may help the body defend itself against certain microorganisms.
Examples of foods with astringent properties include:
(a)Fruits & Vegetables: pomegranate, green apples, cranberries, gooseberries, lemon, tamarind, cucumber, apricots,
(b) Seeds: sesame seeds,pumpkin seeds, sunflower etc.
(c) Black tea

5. ANTIOXIDANT EFFECT

Antioxidant-rich foods help protect our body cells from damage caused by free radicals. Free radicals can be generated naturally through normal processes in the body, as well as through exposure to external factors such as air pollution, cigarette smoke and radiation. When free radicals become excessive or the body is unable to balance them effectively, oxidative stress can occur. Over time, oxidative stress may contribute to cellular damage and has been associated with various health problems, including heart disease and some forms of cancer, as well as processes associated with ageing. Antioxidants found in many plant foods help the body neutralize free radicals and protect cells from oxidative damage. Making a variety of antioxidant-rich foods part of your diet is therefore an important way to support the body's natural defence and maintain overall health.

Examples of antioxidant-rich foods include:
1.Cruciferous vegetables such as broccoli, cauliflower, cabbage, brussels sprouts.
2. Berries such as blueberries, strawberries, raspberries, blackberries.
3. Nuts such as almonds, walnuts, pistachios.
4. Green leafy vegetables.
5. Colourful fruits such as oranges, grapes, cherries and pomegranates.
6. Legumes such as beans, lentils, chickpeas.
7. Green tea
8. Spices such as turmeric, cinnamon, ginger, cloves.
9. Dark chocolate.

6. ANTI-SPASMODIC FOODS

There are foods that can prevent or relieve muscle spasms or cramps, they work by relaxing and calming the muscles, reducing their involuntary contractions or spasms.
Examples of foods that possess certain anti-spasmodic properties are:
(a) Fruits: banana, pineapple, avocado, oranges, papaya, watermelon, dates, apricots, and raisins.

(b) Magnesium-rich foods such as: dark leafy greens, nuts, seeds, legumes and whole grains.
(c) Fatty fish such as: salmon, mackerel,sardines.
(d)Spice: ginger,turmeric,cinnamon,fennel,cloves,black pepper etc.
(e) Herbal teas such as: passion flower,valerian root, lemon balm,

chamomile,peppermint tea.

7. ANALGESIC FOODS

There are some foods that contain natural compounds that may help alleviate pain or discomfort. Many of these foods also have anti-inflammatory properties, which may help reduce inflammation and provide a degree of relief while supporting overall well-being. Because of these properties, such foods are sometimes described as having a "pain-relieving" effect. Including a variety of these foods in your diet can provide the body with anti-inflammatory nutrients and beneficial plant compounds that may support its natural response to inflammation and discomfort.
Examples of foods that may offer analgesic effects include:
(a)Spices & herbs : ginger, turmeric, green tea.
(b) Fatty fish such as salmon, mackerel, sardines.
(c) Extra virgin olive oil.
(d) Dark leafy vegetables such as spinach, kale, swiss chard . (e)Fruits: cherries, walnuts, almonds,pineapple,blueberries, strawberries, raspberries.
(f) Seeds: flaxseeds, chiaseeds,hemp seed, sunflower, sesame seeds.

8**. ENERGY-BOOSTING EFFECT**

There are certain foods that can help increase and sustain the body's energy levels because of their nutrient composition and their role in energy metabolism. They provide carbohydrates, protein, healthy fats, vitamins, minerals and other nutrients that support the body's energy production and help reduce fatigue.
Examples of energy-boosting foods include:
(a) Whole grains and starchy foods such as oats and sweet potatoes, which provide carbohydrates for a steady supply of energy.
(b) Fruits such as bananas, apples, berries and oranges, which provide natural sugars, fibre and antioxidants for readily available energy.
(c) Protein-rich foods such as beans, lean meats, poultry, fish and tofu, which provide amino acids that support energy metabolism, muscle function and recovery.
(d) Nuts and seeds such as almonds, walnuts, chia seeds and flaxseeds, which provide

healthy fats, protein and fibre that help provide lasting energy.
(e) Green leafy vegetables such as spinach and kale, which provide iron, magnesium, and other nutrients involved in energy production and may help reduce fatigue.
(f) Dark chocolate.
(g) Water, which is essential for normal body functions. Even mild dehydration can contribute to tiredness and fatigue.

9. ANTIMICROBIAL EFFECT

In this context, we are considering harmful microorganisms such as bacteria, viruses and fungi. These microorganisms are found everywhere; in the air, water, soil and even within living organisms. Certain foods contain natural compounds with antimicrobial properties that may help the body defend itself against harmful microorganisms and support overall health.

These antimicrobial compounds may help inhibit the growth or activity of certain microorganisms, including bacteria, viruses and fungi.
Let's look at this under these categories:

(i) ANTIFUNGAL EFFECT

Common fungal infections of the human body include athlete's foot, ringworm, nail infections, vaginal yeast infections and some oral and oesophageal fungal infections. Certain foods and natural substances contain compounds with potential antifungal properties that may help inhibit the growth of certain fungi.
Examples include:
(a) Coconut oil, apple cider vinegar, oregano oil, grapefruit seed extract,
(b) Spice: ginger, garlic, oregano, thyme, cinnamon, cloves etc.

(ii) ANTIVIRAL EFFECT

Viral infections are caused by viruses and can include illnesses such as influenza (flu), the common cold, herpes, COVID-19 and measles, to mention a few. Certain foods contain compounds that have been associated with potential antiviral activity and may support the body's natural defences.
Examples include:
(a) Citrus fruits, berries, green tea, yoghurt,
(b) Spice: garlic, ginger,turmeric etc.

(iii) ANTIBACTERIAL EFFECT

Certain foods contain natural compounds with antibacterial properties that may help inhibit the growth or activity of some bacteria and support the body's natural defence system.
Examples include:
(a) garlic, ginger, turmeric, cinnamon,
(b)cranberries, green tea, honey,etc.

10. ANTI-PARASITIC EFFECT

There are certain foods and natural substances that contain compounds with potential anti-parasitic properties. When included as part of a wholesome diet, they may support the body's natural defences and digestive health. Some of these foods have traditionally been used to support the body when dealing with intestinal parasites and may help inhibit the growth or activity of certain parasites.
Examples of foods with anti-parasitic properties include:
(a) Seeds: pumpkin seeds, papaya seeds, sunflower seeds,
(b) garlic, onions, carrots.
(b) fermented foods.

11. WEIGHT-MANAGEMENT EFFECT

The effect of food on body weight depends on several factors, including the type and quantity of food consumed, portion sizes, individual metabolism, physical activity and overall dietary habits. Consistently consuming more energy than the body uses can contribute to weight gain, while consuming less energy than the body uses can contribute to weight loss. Certain foods can support healthy weight management by promoting feelings of fullness, providing essential nutrients, and helping to maintain stable energy levels.
Examples include:
(a) Whole grains: oat, quinoa,brown rice, maize,sorghum etc
(b) protein-rich foods such as lean meat, skinless poultry, fish, tofu, greek yoghurt, eggs and legumes,
(c) Colourful fruits and vegetables,
(d) Nuts and seeds: Sesame seed,almond,cashew nut, pumpkin seed etc
(e) Herbs and spices such as cayenne pepper, ginger, turmeric and cinnamon, green tea and other wholesome foods.

12. ANTI-INFLAMMATORY EFFECT

Inflammation is the body's natural way of protecting itself from harmful stimuli and injury. It can cause symptoms such as pain, swelling, heat and redness. Incorporating anti-inflammatory foods into your daily diet can help support the body's natural response to inflammation and reduce the risk of some chronic diseases associated with persistent inflammation.
Examples are:
(a) Fatty fish such as salmon, sardines and mackerel.
(b) Berries such as strawberries, blueberries, raspberries and blackberries.
(c)Dark leafy greens such as spinach, kale and collard greens.
(d) Others are:turmeric, ginger, tomatoes, whole grains, nuts and seeds, etc.

13. ANTI-ANGIOGENIC EFFECT

Angiogenesis is the natural process by which the body forms new blood vessels. This is a normal and important process involved in growth, development and tissue repair. However, some tumours can stimulate the formation of new blood vessels to obtain oxygen and nutrients which may support their continued growth. Certain foods contain natural compounds that have been studied for their potential anti-angiogenic properties. These compounds may influence some of the pathways involved in blood-vessel formation and may therefore have a supportive role in a healthy diet.
Including a variety of these foods in the diet may therefore provide beneficial plant compounds that support the body's natural protective processes.

Examples of foods and natural substances that have been studied for potential anti-angiogenic effects include:
(a) Seeds and oils such as flaxseed and flaxseed oil
(b) Vegetables: kale, beetroot, artichokes, parsley, tomatoes, red onions and mushrooms
(c) Spices and herbs such as garlic, turmeric, nutmeg, lavender, ginseng, cinnamon and liquorice.
(d) Beverages and other foods like green tea, herbal tea, tigernut drink, olive oil and grapes.
(e) Seafood such as tuna, sea cucumbers and dark chocolate.

PLEASE NOTE
Shark cartilage and shark liver oil have been discussed in some natural-health literature for their potential anti-angiogenic properties. They have been proposed as substances that may influence the formation of new blood vessels; however, current evidence is not sufficient to establish this claim.Their potential role as supportive

measures alongside appropriate treatment remains an area that warrants further research.

14. ANTI-METASTATIC EFFECT

Cancerous cells can metastasise, meaning they can spread from their primary location to other parts of the body, forming secondary growths. There are certain foods that contain natural compounds that have been studied for their potential anti-metastatic properties. These foods may help support the body's natural protective mechanisms and may influence some of the processes involved in the spread of cancerous cells.

The aim is to support the body in maintaining a healthy internal environment and, potentially, help limit processes associated with cancer cell invasion and spread.
Examples of foods in this category are:
(a) Fruits such as berries, citrus fruits, avocado,walnuts
(b) Cruciferous vegetables such as broccoli, cauliflower, brussels sprouts and kale, tomatoes, leafy greens.
(c)Fatty fish such as mackerel and salmon.
(d)Others are whole grains, legumes, healthy fats, flaxseeds, chia seeds, almonds,green tea etc.

Please note
Many of the foods mentioned above contain compounds that are being investigated for their potential effects on cancer-cell invasion, migration, and other processes associated with metastasis. While this area of nutrition and cancer research is promising, the extent to which dietary intake can directly prevent or stop metastasis requires further scientific investigation.

15. IMMUNE-MODULATING EFFECT

The immune system needs to maintain a healthy balance. When it is too weak, the body may have difficulty defending itself against infections and other challenges. When it becomes overactive or improperly regulated, it may contribute to inflammatory and autoimmune conditions. Certain foods contain nutrients and natural compounds that may help modulate or regulate immune function. In other words, they may support the immune system when it needs strengthening while also helping to maintain a balanced immune response.
Examples of such foods are:
(a) citrus fruits,like oranges, grapefruits, lemons, and limes.

(b) berries such as raspberries, strawberries and blueberries. (c)Others are: garlic, ginger, yoghurt, green leafy vegetables such as spinach, kale and broccoli, turmeric, mushrooms, almonds, green tea, etc.

Please note:
The immune-modulating properties of many foods and their bioactive compounds are being actively studied. Their effects may vary depending on the individual, the food consumed and the person's health status. This makes the relationship between nutrition and immune regulation an important area for continued research.

16. HORMONE-BALANCING EFFECT

Hormonal imbalance can affect many functions in the body and may contribute to a variety of health concerns, particularly in women. Certain foods provide nutrients and natural compounds that may help support healthy hormone production, metabolism and regulation.
Examples include:
(a) Cruciferous vegetables such as broccoli, cabbage and brussels sprouts.
(b) Nuts and seeds: flaxseeds, chiaseeds, pumpkin seeds, sunflower, almond.
(c) Fermented foods such as yoghurt, sauerkraut and kefir,
(d) soy products such as tofu and tempeh,
(e) Others are : berries,avocado, salmon, dark chocolate, etc.

17. DETOXIFYING EFFECT

There are certain foods that contain nutrients and natural compounds that can support the body's natural detoxification processes. Many are also rich in fibre and water, which can support regular bowel movements and the healthy elimination of waste from the digestive system.
Examples include:
(a)Spices: turmeric, garlic, ginger,
(b)Fruits & Vegetables: artichokes, beetroot,grapefruit, collard greens, lemon, dandelion, broccoli, watercress, seaweed.
(c) Others are: Water, lemongrass, basil.

18. ALKALIZING EFFECT

There are certain foods that can help support the body's acid-base balance. Many of these foods are rich in minerals and other nutrients, including potassium, magnesium and calcium. Although foods can influence the body's acid load, the body carefully

regulates blood pH through the lungs and kidneys.
Examples include:
(a) Fruits: Cucumber, avocado,watermelon , lemons etc
(b) Others are: leafy green vegetables, broccoli, almonds, celery etc.

19. Oxygenating Effect :
There are certain foods that can support oxygenation in the body by providing nutrients necessary for optimal respiratory function and healthy blood circulation. These foods may help support the body's ability to transport and use oxygen effectively.
Examples of foods that could help to support oxygenation are foods rich in omega-3 fatty acids, such as:
(a) flax seed, chia seeds, hemp seeds,
(b) Fatty fish such as salmon, mackerel, sardines,trout and tuna, algal oil,
(c)soybeans and soy products,
(d) beetroot, citrus fruits, watermelon,walnuts,
(e) Others are: leafy green vegetables,, dark chocolate, turmeric, ginger,garlic, legumes etc

20. Anti-Neoplastic Effect.

Anti-neoplastic foods contain nutrients and natural compounds that have been studied for their potential anti-cancer properties. These foods may support the body's natural protective mechanisms and contribute to a healthy dietary pattern.
Examples are:
cruciferous vegetables such as broccoli, cauliflower, cabbage, brussels sprouts, kale, collard greens, watercress, radishes and mustard greens, berries, garlic, soursop etc

When you understand the work food can do in your body, you begin to make food choices with greater wisdom and intention. Food is more than something placed on a plate. The choices we make every day can become an expression of how intentionally we care for the body God has entrusted to us.

Eat intelligently. Let your food work for you. Nourish your body wisely.

Reflect & Journal

Take a moment to reflect on what you have discovered about the many ways food can interact with and support your body.

1. Which of the effects of food discussed in this chapter was most surprising or meaningful to me, and why?

_____
_____
_____
_____

2. Do I now look at food differently as simply something to satisfy hunger, or as something that can also nourish, protect and support my body?

_____
_____
_____
_____

3. Which foods in my regular diet could I begin choosing more intentionally because of the benefits they may offer?

_____
_____
_____
_____

4.Are there foods I regularly consume that may be working against the health I desire?

_____
_____
_____
_____

5.What one change will I make to my food choices this week as a result of what I have learned?

_____
_____
_____
_____

BUKOLADOWO

Today's Action

Before eating, look at your plate and ask yourself:

What is this food going to do for my body?

Choose a variety of wholesome foods and eat slowly and mindfully. As you eat, pay attention to the colour, aroma, taste, texture, and how satisfied you feel.

After the meal, pause and ask yourself:

How do I feel physically and mentally? Did I choose this meal intentionally, or simply out of habit or convenience?

Write down one thing you noticed and one food choice you would like to improve at your next meal.

_____
_____
_____
_____

Scriptural Reference

> "So whether you eat or drink or whatever you do, do it all for the glory of God." — 1 Corinthians 10:31

Eat Intelligently Tip

> ''Healing begins long before you enter a hospital; it begins with what you put on your plate each day''

BUKOLA IDOWU

Chapter 10: Ten Commandments of Healthy Living

As I conclude this insightful journey into what **intelligent eating** is all about, I would like to include a short note from one of my itinerant health presentations, where I spoke on the topic: **"10 Commandments of Healthy Living."**

Just as God gave the Israelites the **Ten Commandments** through Moses as guiding principles for righteous living, I have, based on my knowledge and experience in **naturopathy and healthy living**, summed up some of the fundamental principles of healthy living into **ten simple instructions**.

I call them the **"10 Commandments of Healthy Living"** because they are practical principles that I believe we should intentionally and consistently practise to **help prevent disease, support the body's natural healing processes and promote better health**, particularly when we are experiencing ill-health or managing a health condition.

The word **"commandments"** is used here to emphasise the importance of making these healthy practices a **consistent and intentional part of our daily lives**. These ten principles are drawn from my experience in naturopathy and my commitment to promoting healthy living principles that I have personally practised and taught others over the years.

My desire is to encourage you to care wisely for the body God has given to you and to make healthy living a consistent part of your daily life.

1. Start Your Day with Water

After several hours of sleep, your body has gone without water, so beginning your morning with water is a simple way to rehydrate and support normal body functions. Warm or room-temperature water can be soothing and may also help get the digestive system moving and support a regular bowel movement, especially when you are adequately hydrated throughout the day.

As you go through your early morning routine; praying, doing a little exercise, cleaning, or simply preparing for the day,you can gradually drink about 50–70 cl of warm or room-temperature water. After drinking the water, allow about one hour before having breakfast

Starting the day this way can help you feel refreshed, hydrated and ready for the day ahead.

2. Drink Enough Water Throughout the Day

Scientific research shows that about 60% of the human body is water. This alone tells us how important water is to the proper functioning of our organs and body systems. Every organ and body system depends on adequate hydration to function properly. Water helps transport nutrients, regulate body temperature, support digestion and remove waste products from the body. Staying well hydrated is one of the simplest ways to care for the body God has given us.

While your daily water needs vary according to factors such as your activity level, climate, diet and individual needs, make water your primary drink. Do not wait until you feel very thirsty before drinking; develop the habit of taking water regularly throughout the day.

When you are thirsty, choose water rather than reaching for a carbonated or sugary drink. Although such drinks contain water and can contribute to your fluid intake, they are not the best substitute for plain water. Many contain added sugars, artificial sweeteners, acids, caffeine, or other additives that can make them less desirable as your everyday source of hydration. Regularly choosing these drinks instead of water may also increase your intake of unnecessary sugar and calories. When your body is asking for water, give it water!

3. Eat Fruits Every Day

Fruits are one of the simplest and most enjoyable ways to nourish the body naturally. They provide vitamins, minerals, fibre, antioxidants and other beneficial plant nutrients that support the body's normal functions and contribute to overall health.

From my perspective in naturopathy and healthy living, I encourage making fruits a regular part of your diet rather than seeing them as something to eat only occasionally. Nature has given us an amazing variety of fruits, each with its own colour, flavour and nutrients.

Fruits can also be a healthier way to satisfy the desire for something sweet. Choosing a naturally sweet fruit instead of sweets, pastries, or sugary snacks may help you reduce your intake of added sugars and, for some people, curb the desire for highly processed sweet foods.

You do not have to eat the same fruit every day. Enjoy variety. Eat what is available and in season. Enjoy fruits that are naturally grown in your environment. You can eat them whole, add them to meals, enjoy them as a snack, fruit juice or nutritious smoothies when appropriate.

Fruits are also a wonderful reminder of God's provision. From the beginning, God provided fruit-bearing trees and plants as food for humanity.

4. Get Enough Quality Sleep

Sleep is not a luxury or a sign of laziness; **it is an essential part of caring for the body God has entrusted to us.** Just as the body needs nourishing food and adequate water, it also needs sufficient rest to function at its best.

While we sleep, the body is not simply “switched off.” It enters a period of **restoration and repair**. During quality sleep, the body carries out important processes that support the **immune system, brain function, tissue repair and overall recovery**. This is why consistently depriving yourself of sleep can eventually affect your health.

As a healthy-living enthusiast, I encourage people not only to get enough sleep but also to develop a healthy **sleep rhythm**. Our bodies have an internal biological clock, known as the **circadian rhythm**, which helps regulate our natural sleep-wake cycle and responds to the daily pattern of light and darkness. Going to bed at a reasonably early and consistent time allows us to work with, rather than against, this natural rhythm.

This is also one reason I encourage you to finish your evening meal about 2–3 hours before bedtime whenever possible. Going to bed immediately after a heavy meal means your digestive system is still actively processing food while your body is preparing for nighttime rest. Allowing some time after dinner gives your body an opportunity to settle before sleep and may help you sleep more comfortably.

The late-night hours should therefore be treated as a time for rest, restoration and the body's normal maintenance processes, rather than a time for heavy meals, unnecessary snacking or staying awake unnecessarily.

Although sleep requirements vary with age and individual needs, most adults need about 7–9 hours of quality sleep each night. Children and teenagers generally require more.

Eat early. Rest well. Give your body time to restore.

5. Enjoy Daily Sunlight

Sunlight is one of God's natural provisions, given to support our overall well-being. Early morning sunlight contains ultraviolet B (UVB) rays, which help the skin produce vitamin D, an important nutrient for healthy bones, muscles and normal immune function.Spending some time outdoors each day can be beneficial to our emotional well-being and may help improve mood especially for people experiencing low mood or a state of depression.

As a healthy-living enthusiast, I encourage making appropriate sunlight a regular part of your daily routine. You do not need to spend long hours in the sun. The goal is sensible, regular exposure, not prolonged exposure that leaves the skin burning or damaged.

For those living in Nigeria, as well as other tropical and sub-Saharan regions, sunlight can become intense relatively early in the day. Early morning is therefore a comfortable time for many people to enjoy outdoor light, although the appropriate duration varies with skin type, location, season and the strength of the sun.

You can combine your sunlight time with other healthy habits: take a morning prayer walk, exercise, read or simply sit quietly and enjoy the free gift of sunlight God has provided**.** Avoid looking directly at the sun and when the sun becomes intense, seek shade or use appropriate protection such as clothing, a hat or sunscreen.

Enjoy God's sunlight wisely; not too little, not too much, but in a way that supports your health while protecting your skin.

6. Practise Intermittent Fasting Weekly

Intermittent fasting is the intentional practice of creating a period when you do not eat, followed by a defined period in which you eat. One of the most commonly studied approaches is the 16:8 method. Out of the 24 hours in a day, 16 hours will be allotted for fasting followed by an 8-hour eating window. During the fasting period, water and other calorie-free drinks may be taken.

Fasting gives the body a break from continuous eating and allows you to become more intentional about when, why and how much you eat. It can help reduce unnecessary snacking and for some people, support healthy weight management and blood-sugar regulation. Research has also found improvements in some measures of insulin

resistance and glucose regulation among certain people following time-restricted eating.

How Does the 16:8 Method Work?

You choose an 8 hour eating window and allow the remaining 16 hours for fasting.

For example:

12:00 noon – 8:00 p.m.: Eating window
8:00 p.m. – 12:00 noon the following day: Fasting window

During the fasting period, drink water regularly. Avoid sugary drinks and other calorie-containing beverages if you want to maintain the fasting period.

You can adjust the timing of your 8 hour eating window to suit your lifestyle. What matters is developing a consistent pattern rather than fasting randomly.

What Happens During the Fast?

When you stop eating, your body continues to use the energy already available to it. As the fasting period progresses, the body can increasingly draw on stored energy, including stored fat, although the extent varies from person to person. Intermittent fasting may also naturally reduce overall food intake because there is less time available for eating.

This is one reason I encourage fasting as part of a broader healthy-living lifestyle, not as a punishment for eating, but as a way of developing discipline, intentionality and a healthier relationship with food.

What Should You Eat During the 8 Hour Window?

Fasting does not give us permission to spend the eating window eating whatever we want. The quality of your food still matters. Make your meals nourishing and balanced, with plenty of vegetables, whole fruits, legumes, whole grains, healthy fats and appropriate protein sources. Avoid using the eating window as an opportunity to overeat highly processed foods, sugary drinks or excessive snacks.

If you have been fasting for several hours, break your fast gently rather than rushing into a very large meal. A meal containing wholesome, minimally processed foods is a better way to nourish the body.

Any Health Benefit?

For some adults, particularly those with overweight, obesity, prediabetes or type 2 diabetes, time-restricted eating may support weight management and improve aspects of blood-glucose regulation. However, fasting should be viewed as one possible lifestyle adjustment that, when practised appropriately and consistently, can become part of a healthy-living routine. It should not be regarded as a cure for disease.

If you have diabetes, especially if you use insulin or certain blood-sugar lowering medicines, do not begin intermittent fasting without appropriate medical guidance. Fasting can cause dangerously low or high blood sugar in some circumstances and medication timing or dosage may need to be adjusted.

Fasting is not only about food. Throughout Scripture, fasting is associated with prayer, humility, self-control and seeking God.

> *"When you fast..."* **Matthew 6:16–18**

Use your fasting period as an opportunity to pray, reflect, exercise self-discipline and become more conscious of your physical and spiritual needs.

> **Fast with purpose. Eat with wisdom. Nourish your body intentionally.**

7. Exercise Regularly

Our bodies were made to move. Exercise is not only about losing weight or changing how you look; it is one of the simple ways we care for the body God has entrusted to us. When we move regularly, we strengthen our muscles and bones, support heart health, improve circulation and promote emotional well-being.

As a healthy-living enthusiast, I encourage you not to see exercise as something you do only when you want to lose weight or when you have time for the gym. Movement should become part of your everyday life. You do not need expensive equipment or a gym membership to stay active. A brisk walk, jogging, dancing, cycling, swimming, skipping, stretching, gardening, household chores, or simple exercises at home can all keep your body moving.

The important thing is to choose activities you enjoy and can do consistently. You may prefer a morning walk, a few stretches after waking up, dancing to your favourite

music, or an evening walk after work. There is no need to make exercise complicated. What matters is making movement a regular part of your lifestyle.

Regular physical activity can help strengthen the heart, improve circulation, maintain healthy muscles and bones, support healthy weight management, improve blood-sugar regulation, increase stamina, reduce stress, improve mood and promote better sleep. It can also help you maintain mobility and independence as you grow older.

If you have been inactive for some time, do not feel pressured to start with intense exercise. Start where you are and build gradually. Even short periods of movement throughout the day are better than sitting for long periods without activity. Listen to your body, stay hydrated and give yourself enough time to recover.

Remember, exercise should strengthen and support your body, not become a punishment. You do not have to exhaust yourself to benefit from movement. Find something you enjoy, make it part of your routine, and keep going.

Move your body. Enjoy the gift of movement.

8. Eat More Natural Foods and Less Processed Food

Natural foods are foods that come from nature, whether from the land or water, and have undergone little or no processing before we eat them. They include fresh fruits, vegetables, legumes, whole grains, nuts, seeds, seafood and other foods that remain close to their original form.

Processed foods, on the other hand, are foods that originally come from natural sources but have undergone some form of preparation or alteration before they are eaten. This may involve cooking, drying, milling, freezing, canning, fermentation, or adding ingredients to improve their taste, texture, appearance, or shelf life.

Although food processing can have useful purposes, such as preserving food, improving safety and extending its shelf life. The more a food is altered, the further it may move from its original form. Some processing methods can reduce certain nutrients, while added ingredients such as excess salt, sugar, unhealthy fats, colours, flavours and preservatives may make the food less desirable as an everyday choice.

This is why I encourage making natural and minimally processed foods the mainstay of your diet whenever possible. Foods in their natural or simple form generally provide

the body with a combination of nutrients, fibre and other beneficial substances without the need for unnecessary additives.

For example, fresh carrot can be eaten raw when appropriate or gently cooked, allowing you to enjoy its natural nutrients and fibre. Compare this with some canned vegetables, which may contain added salt or other ingredients used during processing and preservation.
The same applies to fruits:
A fresh orange provides fibre, vitamins, minerals and other beneficial plant substances in its natural form. This is quite different from a packaged fruit drink that may contain added sugar, flavourings, preservatives and only a small fraction of the nutritional value of the whole fruit.

Your body is wonderfully equipped to digest and use nutrients from food. Why complicate what nature has already provided? Whenever possible, choose foods that are close to their original form, prepare them simply and enjoy the nourishment they provide.

This does not mean that every processed food is bad or that you must completely eliminate all foods that have been processed. Processing can sometimes make food safer, more convenient, or easier to store. The concern is with relying heavily on highly processed foods that have been altered considerably and often contain excess sugar, salt, unhealthy fats and additives while providing relatively little nutritional value.

A simple way to make better choices is to let natural or minimally processed foods form the foundation of your meals. Choose fresh fruits and vegetables, beans and other legumes, whole grains, nuts, seeds and other wholesome foods more often. When possible, prepare your meals yourself so you have greater control over what goes into them.

Learn to read food labels too. The longer and more complicated the ingredient list, the more carefully you should consider what you are buying. Do not be deceived by attractive packaging or health claims on the label of a product. Turn the package around, look at the ingredients and nutritional information.

Another helpful habit is to gradually reduce your dependence on sugary drinks, packaged snacks, instant meals, refined foods, processed meats and other highly processed foods. You do not have to change everything overnight. Small, consistent changes can make a significant difference over time.

Think of it this way: eat foods that look more like the foods God created and less like the products manufactured in a factory.
The goal is not perfection; it is to make wholesome choices more often.

> **Choose real food more often. Read your labels. Nourish your body wisely.**

9. Rest and Avoid Excessive Stress

Life can be demanding. There will always be responsibilities and challenges beyond our control. However, living under constant stress and worry can take a toll on both the mind and the body. This is why rest, relaxation and learning how to manage stress are important parts of healthy living.

Rest is more than simply sleeping at night. It also means giving your mind and body regular opportunities to slow down, recover and recharge. Make time to pause from work and daily responsibilities. Take a walk, spend time in nature, pray, listen to music, go on vacation, enjoy meaningful conversations, or simply sit quietly without feeling guilty about doing nothing.

Pay attention to the things that continually leave you feeling overwhelmed. Sometimes healthy living requires us to slow down, set boundaries, say no when necessary and stop carrying responsibilities that are beyond our control. You cannot always change what is happening around you, but you can learn healthier ways to respond to it.

Stress itself is not always harmful. Short periods of stress are a normal part of life. The concern is persistent or excessive stress without adequate recovery. When stress becomes constant, it can affect sleep, mood, appetite, concentration and other aspects of well-being.

As part of a healthy lifestyle, make rest intentional. Do not wait until your body breaks down before you give it permission to rest. Build moments of rest into your daily routine and allow yourself time away from work and unnecessary demands.

Most importantly, learn to take your worries to God. Prayer, gratitude, faith and trusting God can help bring perspective and peace when life feels overwhelming.

Rest is not laziness, and taking a break does not mean you are unproductive. Sometimes, resting is exactly what the body and mind need to continue well.

Slow down. Breathe. Rest. Trust God. Live well.

10. Maintain a Healthy Social Life

We were not created to live in isolation. Healthy relationships are an important part of a healthy life. Family, friends, neighbours, colleagues and other meaningful relationships can provide love, encouragement, companionship, accountability and emotional support.

Having people you can talk to, laugh with, pray with, share your experiences with and turn to when life becomes difficult can make a real difference to your overall well-being. Positive social connections can help reduce feelings of loneliness, lift your mood and give you a sense of belonging and purpose.

However, maintaining a healthy social life is not about having a large number of friends or being constantly surrounded by people. It is about having meaningful and healthy relationships. Choose relationships that encourage growth, mutual respect, honesty, kindness and peace. At the same time, learn to recognise relationships that consistently drain you, encourage unhealthy habits, or rob you of your peace. Always avoid toxic relationship.

Be intentional about staying connected. Call someone you care about, visit a loved one, share a meal, take a walk together, join a meaningful group, or simply spend quality time with the people who matter to you. Sometimes, a simple conversation or a listening ear is all someone needs.

Healthy relationships also require us to play our own part. Be the kind of friend, family member, neighbour, or colleague you would want to have. Listen when others need to talk, offer encouragement, forgive where possible, apologise when you are wrong and celebrate the successes of others.

Your social well-being is connected to your emotional and mental well-being. A healthy life is not only about what you eat or how much you exercise; it is also about the people you share life with.

Connect meaningfully. Love generously. Grow together. Live well.

Chapter 11: Transforming Your Kitchen into a Natural Pharmacy

> **"The greatest medicine of all is teaching people how not to need it."**
> Hippocrates

Your kitchen may be one of the most powerful places in your home when it comes to your health.

Every day, you make choices about what enters your body. Some foods nourish, protect and strengthen the body, while others may simply satisfy hunger without providing much nutritional value.

This is why your kitchen deserves intentional attention.

What if your kitchen could become a place that supports healing, nourishment and prevention?

The goal is not to turn your kitchen into a literal pharmacy or to suggest that food replaces necessary medical treatment. Rather, it is to make your kitchen a place where **real, nourishing foods and natural ingredients are readily available and where healthy choices become the easier choices.**

What Should a Natural Kitchen Look Like?

A natural kitchen is not necessarily an expensive kitchen. It is a kitchen where whole and minimally processed foods have a prominent place.

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A Simple Kitchen Transformation

You do not have to empty your kitchen overnight. Start gradually.

Replace.
Replace sugary drinks with water more often.

Reduce.
Reduce your dependence on highly processed foods.

Add.
Add more fruits, vegetables, legumes, whole grains, herbs and spices.

Prepare.
Prepare more of your meals from recognizable ingredients.

Invest.
Purchase kitchen equipment that makes healthy preparation easier.

Organize.
Place nourishing foods where they are easy to see and reach.

Your kitchen does not have to be perfect.

It simply needs to become **more intentional.**

Reflect & Journal

1. What foods dominate my kitchen at the moment?

_____
_____
_____
_____

2. Are whole and minimally processed foods readily available in my home?

_____
_____
_____
_____

4. Which “foodless foods” do I consume most frequently?

_____
_____
_____
_____

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5.What three healthy foods should I begin stocking regularly?

_____
_____
_____
_____

6. Which kitchen appliance would make healthy eating easier for me?

_____
_____
_____
_____

7. What unhealthy kitchen habit can I replace this week?

_____
_____
_____
_____

8. If my kitchen reflected my health priorities, what would I need to change?

_____
_____
_____
_____

Today's Action

Give your kitchen a health makeover.
Open your refrigerator, freezer, cupboards and pantry.
Sort what you find into four simple categories:
1. **KEEP:**
Nourishing foods you want to eat regularly.
2. **REDUCE:**
Foods you want to consume less frequently.
3. **REPLACE:**
Less nourishing choices for which you can find better alternatives.
4. **ADD:**
Whole foods, fruits, vegetables, herbs, spices and other nourishing ingredients you want to introduce.

Then choose **one kitchen appliance or tool** that would make healthy food preparation easier for you.

You do not need to buy it immediately. Research it, compare quality and durability, and plan your investment wisely.

_____
_____
_____
_____

Scriptural Reference

> "Whether therefore ye eat, or drink, or whatsoever ye do, do all to the glory of God." 1 Corinthians 10:31

Eat Intelligently Tip

> Do not just stock your kitchen, design it.

A kitchen filled with nourishing ingredients, useful tools and ready-to-eat healthy options can make intelligent eating easier every day.

Your kitchen should help you practise what you have learned in this journal.

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Conclusion: Your Journey to Lifelong Healthy Living

Your journey through *Eat Intelligently* may be coming to an end, but your journey to healthy living is just beginning.

You have learned that food is more than something that fills the stomach. It can nourish, protect, strengthen and support the body. You have explored the importance of eating wholesome foods, making wise choices, understanding portions, choosing natural ingredients and creating habits that support your well-being.

Healthy living is not about perfection; it is about consistent, intentional choices. Every meal, every habit and every day gives you another opportunity to care for your body.

My Personal Commitment

I commit to making my health a daily priority.
I will:
choose nourishing, wholesome foods more often.
drink enough water and reduce unnecessary sugary drinks.
include more fruits and vegetables in my meals.
practice mindful eating and pay attention to portion sizes.
make healthier choices when shopping and preparing food.
stay physically active and make time for adequate rest.
avoid the mindset of perfection and simply get back on track when I make a poor choice.
continue learning and improving my lifestyle one step at a time.

I will not wait for a health challenge before I begin to take care of myself. I will start where I am, use what I have, and make better choices each day.

Remember, your health is a journey, not a destination.
Take it one meal, one choice and one day at a time.

Eat intelligently. Live intentionally. Nourish your body. Protect your future.

Here's to a healthier, wiser and more intentional you.

BUKUDOMO

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IMPORTANT INFORMATION

Disclaimer

This journal is intended as a guide to help you make healthier food and lifestyle choices. It is not intended to replace professional medical advice, diagnosis, or prescribed medication. Where medical treatment or medication is necessary, always seek the guidance of a qualified healthcare professional and follow the recommended treatment.

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